

Ireland's Defence Procurement Architecture

Outsourcing, improvisation, and the price of buying without a system

A defence strategy is, in the end, a procurement strategy; as every capability a state commits to is something it must buy. Ireland has never intentionally created a defence acquisition strategy, meaning that it is building a defence capability decision by decision, across more than €1 billion in commitments since 2024. Execution is outsourced to another state's procurement machinery, supplier policy is improvised contract by contract, and every major spending award is made without competition.

This paper outlines the strategy Ireland is actually using, prices it, and sets out the architecture that would let the State make its own procurement decisions rather than have them happen to it.

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KEY FINDING In the first week of August 2026, the State published its first-ever national procurement strategy and prepared to sign acquisition orders for the largest defence procurement programme in its history. Neither document acknowledges the other. Three case studies — the Military Radar Programme, the Falcon 6X government jet, and the Presidency counter-drone purchase — reveal a single underlying process: procurement decisions that happen to Ireland's system rather than being made by it. The recurring cost of this arrangement plausibly runs to several hundred million euro across the current pipeline, while the institutional solution costs under €30 million a year.

The Revealed Strategy

On 5 August 2026, the Minister for Public Expenditure, Jack Chambers, stood in Government Buildings to launch *Procuring for our Future*, Ireland's first National Public Procurement Strategy: with five pillars, fifty-one actions, an implementation group, and a mid-term review scheduled for 2028. One of the first questions he faced was about an aircraft; reporters wanted to know whether the State's new €53 million government jet could land in fog, because it had been bought without an Israeli-made vision system that the Government's own supplier policy excluded.

The minister responsible for how the State buys things answered by relaying another department's assertion: the Department of Defence had informed him there were “no limitations on the aircraft's operational capability”. While he had sought clarity from the Department of Defence, he did not get one, because there is no institution that exists in the Irish state that could have given him the appropriate analysis he needed.

That incident is demonstrative of this paper's finding across the board. Ireland now has the outline of a comprehensive, consulted, KPI-tracked strategy for the procurement of goods, services and works across the public system — and no strategy at all for the procurement that is the largest per contract, hardest to run, and least forgiving of error. The new National Strategy names the Department of Defence in one substantive institutional capacity: as one of five Central Purchasing Bodies, a bulk-buyer of routine goods alongside the Health Service Executive and the Education Procurement Service. Further, its glossary defines public

procurement as purchase “through a competitive tendering process”. By that definition, every major defence acquisition of the past two years falls outside the new procurement strategy’s conceptual universe.

The consequences of this are hard to overstate, because procurement sounds administrative. However in the defence domain it is not: defence procurement is the defence strategy. A defence strategy is, in fact, a list of capabilities a state has decided it needs, and every capability on that list is something the state must buy — radar networks, sonar, interceptors, aircraft — since almost none of it is made in Ireland. The €1.7 billion capital programme is therefore not the implementation detail of Irish defence policy; it is Irish defence policy, expressed as purchase orders. And because the State is the only customer for defence goods — there is no defence market without a government being the main buyer — this is also the purest case of the government's role in the economy: a monopsony buyer whose contract decisions determine not only what the Defence Forces can do, but whether an Irish defence industrial base exists in Ireland at all. A state that runs this function without a strategy or the appropriate apparatus has not just delegated an administrative task, it has failed to build the fundamental premise on which its defence policy and a share of its industrial policy, are actually decided.

The pattern those acquisitions form is set out in *Figure 1*. As a whole, they disclose an unwritten strategy with two components:

- (1) **Execution is outsourced:** the radar and armoured vehicle programmes are being run government-to-government, with procurement carried out by the Direction Générale de l'Armement (DGA), the French armaments directorate.
- (2) **Policy is improvised:** the supplier exclusion that shaped the Falcon and counter-drone purchases was applied contract by contract, at an official level, without a published framework.

Thus, it can be inferred that the Irish Department of Defence’s procurement strategy amounts to outsourcing plus improvisation.

Acquisition	Value	Supplier / channel	Route	Competing bids
Naval towed-array sonar (contract June 2025)	€60m reported	Thales DMS (France)	Not disclosed	Not disclosed
Government jet, Falcon 6X (tendered 2023; delivered Dec 2025)	€53m ex-VAT	Dassault Aviation (France)	Tender — negotiated procedure, Dir. 2009/81/EC	Competition held; bidders n/d
Counter-UAS for the EU Presidency (contracted Feb 2026)	€19m	MBDA (European) with Fortem (US)	Fast-tracked negotiation	None reported
Short-range air defence, Mistral (2026)	n/d	MBDA (European)	Announced alongside C-UAS	Not disclosed
Military Radar Programme (2026–28)	€300–500m reported	France (DGA; Thales per reporting)	Government-to-government	None — no tender
Armoured fleet, Scorpion family (preferred partner Feb 2026)	€500–800m reported	France (KNDS with Thales)	Government-to-government	None — no tender

Figure 1: Ireland's major defence acquisitions since 2024, from public reporting. The radar programme's reported cost ranges from “in excess of €300 million” to around €500 million — a €200 million spread that no published business case resolves, because no competing bid was ever priced. The National Public Procurement Strategy, published August 2026, defines public procurement as purchase through competitive tendering; nothing in this table qualifies.

What a Procurement Architecture Is For

A procurement *strategy* and a procurement *mechanism* do different jobs.

The procurement strategy answers the what-and-why questions: which capabilities the State intends to acquire, in what sequence, through which routes — national tender, joint procurement, government-to-government — and with what industrial return expected.

The procurement mechanism is the apparatus that executes the strategy: requirements definition, market engagement, tender design, contract negotiation, delivery management, acceptance testing, lifecycle sustainment.

Together, they form the tightly-coupled conversion layer between money and capability. As such, a budget line is not a capability; rather it is the architecture of a procurement apparatus that turns €1.7 billion into a working radar network rather than into state expenditure.

A mature acquisition system performs six functions.

- (1) **Price discovery:** competition reveals what things should cost.
- (2) **Requirements discipline:** an institutional check on specification drift and gold-plating – the most consequential source of cost over-runs in defence spending.
- (3) **Industrial leverage:** participation and workshare requirements that convert public spending into domestic capability.
- (4) **Lifecycle management:** pricing the thirty-year cost of ownership at the only moment the buyer has leverage, which is before sales contracts are signed.
- (5) **Institutional learning:** each programme trains the people for the next.
- (6) **Values implementation:** the least discussed and — for Ireland in 2026 — most consequential; the apparatus that converts a foreign policy position into an operable supplier rule, with published criteria, a defined supply-chain depth, a capability impact assessment, a waiver process, and periodic review.

The Irish defence acquisition function has the apparatus for none of these functions. Notably, this is not a criticism of the officials involved. Ireland's defence procurement has historically been *sustainment* purchasing — vehicles, uniforms, ammunition, maintenance — and Ireland's general framework handles such commodity purchasing with competence. But what the State has never done until now is engage with *first-generation capability* acquisition. In Ireland, there is no template, no institutional memory, and no personnel expertise in the Department for buying a radar network, because the State has never bought one.

Under the EU Defence and Security Procurement Directive (2009/81/EC), government-to-government contracts are expressly *excluded* from its scope. The route Ireland has chosen for essentially its entire capital programme is therefore the one that removes every layer of procedural discipline simultaneously. Ireland's Department of Defence has not been forced to generate procurement knowledge because its procurement sits outside of the EU directive, outside the new National Strategy, and outside of competitive processes. It has no legal obligation to maintain spending or acquisition discipline in this domain, and thus it has chosen to forego installing the systems that would make it adhere to such standards.

This means that when Ireland awards a €500 million contract without competition, the only mandatory check is *Circular 40/2002*: which dictates that departments must report any un-competed contract above €25,000 to the Comptroller and Auditor General, once a year, in a list.

This requires the State to *record* the decision, but not to *defend* it — as no benchmarks, priced alternatives, or approval is required; regulatory compliance is achieved by just appearing in the list. And the threshold is twenty thousand times smaller than the radar programme, which will pass through the same mechanism as a €26,000 printer contract — the types of procurement that the outdated mechanism was intended to monitor. The C&AG can audit it later, but retrospective audit arrives after the money is spent: it can try to establish what excess premium was paid for a capability, but it cannot recover it.

Figure 2 below maps these functions against Irish reality.

Function	What it does	Irish general public system (2026)	Irish defence acquisition (2026)
Price discovery	Competition reveals cost	Median of 3 bids per tender; 8,004 contracts advertised (2025)	Zero competing bids on any major programme
Requirements discipline	Checks specification drift	Value-for-money circulars; corporate procurement plans	No published requirements methodology
Industrial leverage	Converts spend into domestic capability	88% of contracts awarded to SMEs	No participation policy; no Irish workshare negotiated
Lifecycle management	Prices the 30-year cost, not the sticker	Contract and expenditure management embedded in guidance	No published lifecycle costing for any programme
Institutional learning	Each programme trains the next	Pillar 4: professionalisation pathways, knowledge hub	Learning accrues in Paris
Values implementation	Turns positions into operable supplier rules	Social procurement target: 10% of contracts	Exclusion applied ad hoc; no published framework

Figure 2: The six functions of a mature acquisition system, mapped against the general public procurement system as reformed in August 2026 and against the defence acquisition function. General-system figures are from the National Public Procurement Strategy fact sheet (2025 data).

Three Case Studies

1. The Radar: Route Selection by Incapacity

The Military Radar Programme — long-range land-based radar, ship-borne maritime radar, and ground-based air defence including counter-drone — is the flagship of the €1.7 billion defence capital allocation under the revised National Development Plan. The Government approved the first part of the final business case in July 2026, clearing the way for the early signing of acquisition orders with France; first deliveries are expected in 2027 and a fully operational network by the end of 2028.. The execution is government-to-government, with procurement carried out by the DGA — an organisation whose mission is to equip the French armed forces and to promote French arms exports.

The Minister for Defence's justification, in this light, be interpreted as an institutional document outlining a strategy, in lieu of any other existing. A government-to-government arrangement was, in the procurement team's assessment, “the only feasible way for Ireland to develop the required radar capabilities”. However this is

not a procurement decision; it is an admission that the State's own system cannot buy this capability. Ireland is not *reforming* its procurement system, it is simply creating a *new dependency* on France's.

Three costs ensue:

- (1) **The agent conflict:** Ireland has appointed as its buying agent an organisation whose mandate includes selling French equipment, so the competition that a radar tender would ordinarily generate — between Thales, Leonardo, Hensoldt, or Raytheon — never happened, and price discovery is gone.
- (2) **The leverage:** industrial participation requirements are conditions attached to a contract obliging the supplier to place a share of the work with local firms. Without them, the highest-value procurement in the history of the State spends every euro abroad, with no structured return to Irish firms — and there are none in this deal, because they can only be demanded of a supplier competing to win, and a sole-source arrangement through the DGA has no competition.
- (3) **The learning:** the transition architecture's implicit promise was that delivering the radar would build the acquisition muscle that the next phase needs. However, outsourced execution means Ireland's first first-generation capability build generates almost no Irish institutional memory. The constraint on the Irish defence system is not being solved, but it is being arguably deepened.

Further, the procurement channel is concentrating. The sonar deal was given to Thales, the jet to Dassault, the armoured vehicle negotiation to Paris, and the radar to the DGA. Hence a state that spent two decades leaving one strategic dependency unacknowledged — on the United Kingdom for air policing — is acquiring a second, on France, for procurement capacity — while its declared bilateral security track runs through London.

Thus, Ireland's procurement track and the cooperation track lead to separate dependencies, and no published document explains why.

However: it must be noted that government-to-government procurement is faster, the EU Presidency timetable and the end-2028 target are huge constraints, and Security Ireland has itself argued the virtues of the bilateral channel in the Cork MoU. Hence, this critique should be confined to the inadequacy of the route that was selected by the State's incapacity rather than by a strategy, and without the compensating mechanisms that mature states attach to sole-source deals: participation requirements, independent value-for-money benchmarking, and justified parliamentary reporting.

2. The Falcon: A Position Without A Policy

In August 2024 the Government announced that Ireland would not purchase military equipment containing Israeli-manufactured products — a decision Micheál Martin, then Tánaiste and Minister for Defence, grounded in the International Court of Justice's rulings on the settlements and on Gaza. The new €53 million Falcon 6X — the one acquisition in *Figure 1* confirmed to have been competitively tendered in a 2023 competition run under the defence directive's negotiated procedure — was accordingly ordered without FalconEye, the enhanced flight vision system manufactured by Elbit Systems that assists landing in fog; as installing it would have required a written agreement between the State and Elbit. Yet four months after the Israeli exclusion policy was announced, the same Department signed a €91.7 million contract with Airbus for four H145M helicopters, for delivery from 2027, which reportedly will carry Helionix flight systems — critical cockpit components manufactured by Airbus with Elbit Systems. Further, the C295 maritime patrol aircraft already in service carry Israeli-manufactured radar today.

Together, the three aircraft disclose the policy's *actual* operating form:

- (1) Exclusion where a direct Israeli contract would be required;
- (2) Tolerance of embedded content procured through third-party primes.

Clearly, Israel is not a peripheral supplier a state can easily route around; it is a top-tier defence power whose technology is integrated into nearly every platform in the Western military inventory — including Ireland's. Before Ireland took this position, more than €8.5 million was given to Israeli arms companies in a decade, from the Orbiter drones the Army has flown since 2007 to the Elbit sighting systems on its armoured vehicles serving in Lebanon, plus ground radar, fire-control and communications equipment. And after the Israeli exclusion position was taken, Ireland has retained a maintenance contract with an Israeli state-owned firm; its helicopter contract was signed four months later, carrying Elbit cockpit systems; and the Israeli-manufactured radar still flying on the maritime patrol fleet. Excluding a supplier this embedded is a serious act of policy that carries a huge price that must be extremely well managed; but that cannot be avoided.

But without a procurement architecture, Ireland is unable to manage this complexity. The position to exclude Israeli technology exists only as ministerial remarks; it was never translated into a suite of policies, and so no procurement process was ever built around it — nothing that identifies, for each acquisition, what the exclusion forecloses, what workarounds and alternatives exist and at what price, and, where no workaround exists, whether the State pays more to accept lower capabilities, and by how much. Each of these is a concrete number that was never internally generated. Further, the consequences of this missing architecture run deeper than inconsistent application: the State has denied itself the ability ever to learn the price of its own ideological positions.

The result is the worst of every world. Ireland paid a capability price, in that it no longer has access to whatever the missing system's true operational value; but neither did it achieve an Israeli technology exclusion, as the inventory above shows; while it absorbed a week of international ridicule for a hypocrisy it could have rebutted with a single, stated policy — had any institution actually created it. When asked whether the aircraft can land in low visibility, the Department responded that there are "no limitations on the aircraft's operational capability" — and then supported the claim with a list of what the aircraft can do: its range, its passenger capacity, its mission roles. It declined, "for operational reasons," to discuss the one specification the question was about.

This leads to a discussion on two points.

First, "no limitations": is a claim about requirements, not physics. The aircraft retains a full instrument suite and can fly precision approaches into major airports in very poor visibility; what the missing system provides is the ability to operate below standard minima at airfields without advanced landing infrastructure. Whether that is a limitation therefore depends entirely on what the requirements for the aircraft state — and if the requirement never specified low-visibility performance at non-precision airfields, or was drafted around the aircraft as purchased, then "full operational capability" is true by construction, and perhaps also meaningless.

Second, the aircraft's mission list: is the justification of the €53 million spend; it was defended not simply as a ministerial jet but as an evacuation and medevac asset — and it is precisely those missions, ending at remote airfields in poor weather, that the exclusion decision degrades. The State is defending the price of its jet with a suite of mission that its own policy has compromised: the jet was bought to do the things it is now less able to do.

That contradiction has happened because there is no written policy to prevent it; whereas a published requirements document would make the contradiction impossible, as it would state the primary aircraft roles, the secondary roles, the availability assumption for a fleet of one, the conversion time from executive cabin to stretcher fit, and the equipment each role demands — and the decision to exclude the FalconEye either becomes feasible for the requirements or it does not. Indeed, a mature acquisition institution would have gone further and answered the question with an operational impact assessment: expected diversion rates by mission type, and the difference between destinations with and without instrument-landing infrastructure. That assessment might well vindicate the decision to exclude the FalconEye, however no document suggests that this type of decision-making exists.

Figure 3 draws the decision-making that was skipped.

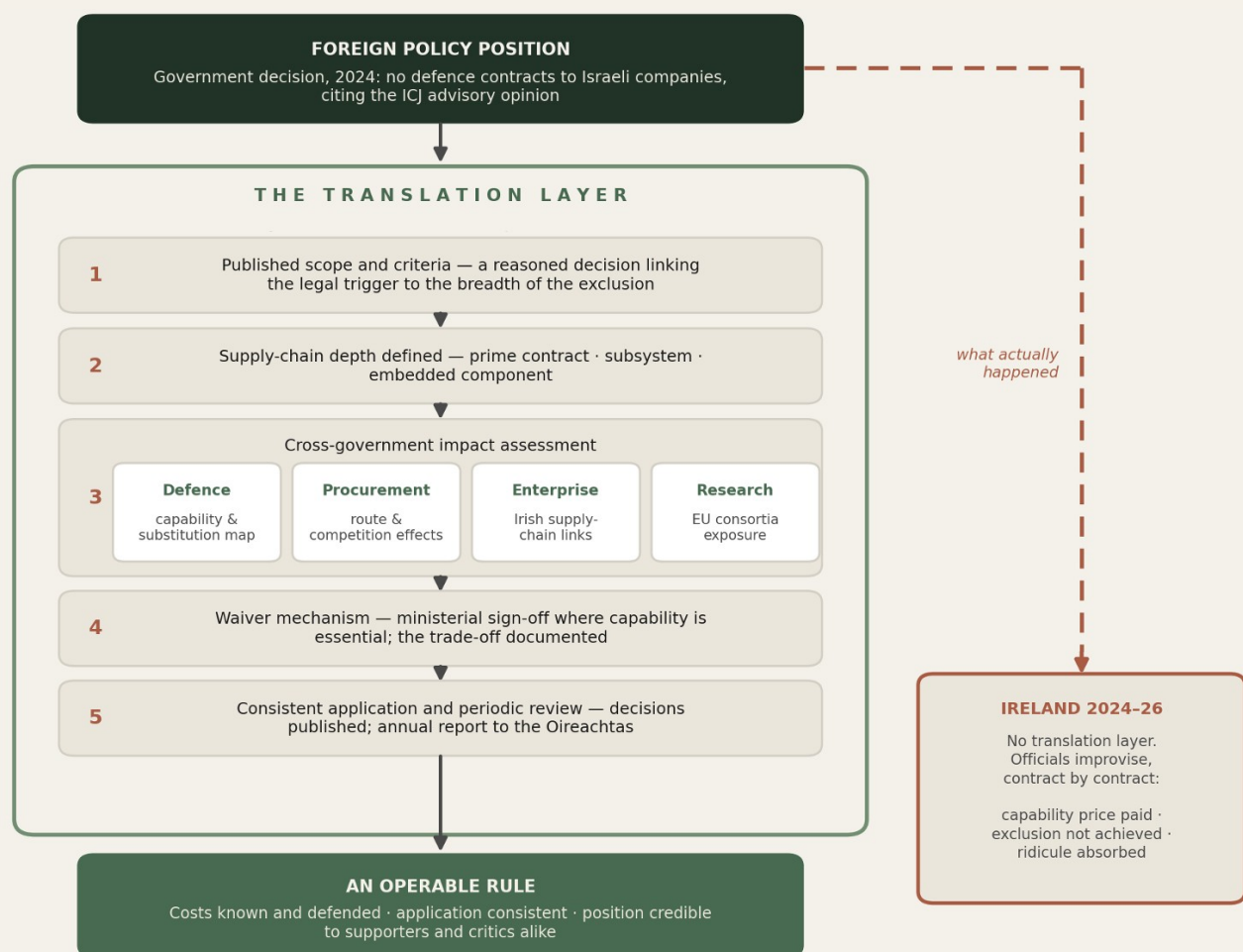


Figure 3: The translation layer Ireland skipped: A mature state runs a values position through published scope, defined supply-chain depth, cross-government impact assessment, a waiver mechanism and periodic review before it touches a contract. Ireland's 2024 decision bypassed every stage — so the State paid the capability price without achieving the exclusion, and could not defend either outcome.

3. The Counter-Drone Purchase: The Interaction Under Pressure

In December 2025, days after unidentified drones were flown during the visit of President Zelenskiy, the Government announced €19 million for a counter-unmanned aerial system to be in place ahead of the EU Presidency. Contracts were concluded by February 2026 and the system delivered in the first half of the year, deployed at Casement Aerodrome: MBDA's Sky Warden detection and command system, with DroneHunter net-firing interceptors made by Fortem Technologies — a US firm owned by a consortium including Lockheed Martin

— with MBDA Mistral short-range air defence missiles also being acquired, replacing the Swedish-made Saab RBS-70.

The purchase is a test case of the unwritten exclusion rule, in the one capability domain where Israeli suppliers — Rafael, Elbit, IAI — are the global benchmark. On the surface, the result looks like a success: Ireland found a non-Israeli system in the one field where Israeli firms lead the world. But look at the conditions under which it was procured: the best suppliers were excluded by the policy; time was desperately short because of the Presidency; the State had never bought a counter-drone system before, and NATO's shared purchasing scheme was closed to it as a non-member. Under those conditions, only one outcome was possible: a rushed purchase, with no competition, from the same Franco-European channel as everything else, at a price no rival bid ever tested. Was the Israeli system cheaper, better, or faster? The State cannot say — it never asked.

Following, compliance was possible here because MBDA's ecosystem happened to offer non-Israeli interceptors. Had the best-integrated effector been Israeli — entirely plausible in this market — officials would have faced the Falcon 6X dilemma again, on a flagship Presidency deliverable, with no framework to manage the complexity of the decision. In this case, the exclusion rule was maintained without obvious trade-offs because of coincidental market conditions. However it could have been different.

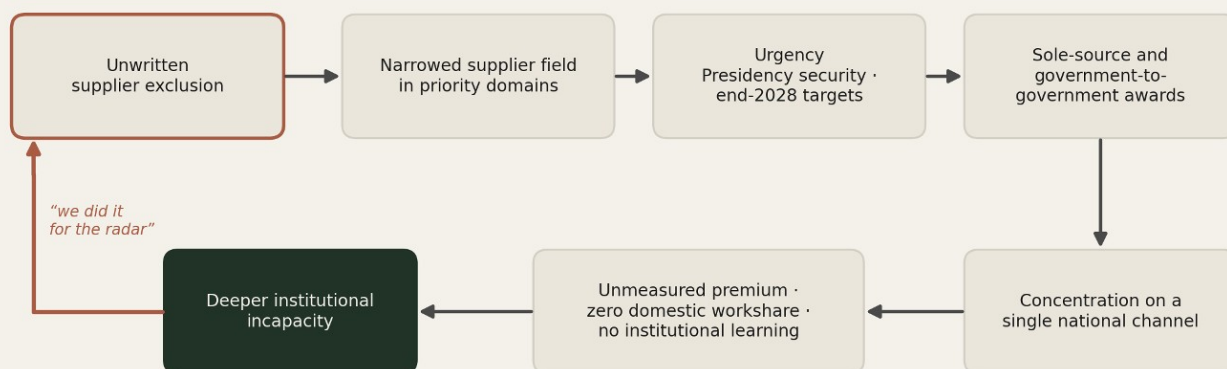


Figure 4: The improvisation loop. Each ad hoc decision reproduces the conditions that made it necessary. The exclusion and the outsourcing are not parallel failures: the first helps cause the second, and each pass makes the next sole-source award easier to wave through.

The Bandwidth Tax

The costs of a missing procurement architecture are real, large, and nowhere accounted for, while the cost of fixing it is small and would appear as a visible budget line.

The sole-source premium is the most common cost: audit and defence-economics literature commonly finds competition saving on the order of 10–20% against sole-source pricing, and no major Irish award since 2024 has faced a competing bid.

The intermediation rent is less visible: government-to-government execution is not free — the US Foreign Military Sales analogue charges a flat 3.2% administrative surcharge, and French arrangements bundle the equivalent less transparently. Ireland is already paying for a procurement institution; it is simply paying for France's.

The forfeited industrial return is quantified in Security Ireland companion papers: a participation policy on the €2.5 billion decade pipeline would plausibly generate €375–750 million in gross domestic workshare; offsets

carry their own cost premium, so the net figure is smaller, but even a conservative third of the gross is material — and the unpriceable part is that no Irish firm exits this programme with a defence reference customer, which is the entire strategic point of domestic defence industries.

The programmatic lock-in is the largest component, but also the least discussed. Acquisition is typically only 30–40% of a platform's lifecycle cost; the €1.7 billion capital programme therefore implies roughly €2.5–4 billion in lifetime sustainment — maintenance, spares, upgrades, training — all contributing to multi-decade dependencies on a country with a different military strategy. This means that for year of the radar network's thirty-year life, the State will pay exceedingly high programmatic prices because of a decision made in 2026.

Unmeasured costs: the Falcon's true operational cost — diversion rates, availability, resale value — is unknown, because no impact assessment appears to exist. A mature state with an exclusion framework would know what its policy costs and could defend paying it. Ireland is paying an unknown price for an unpublished policy.

Figure 5 assembles what could constitute as a solution:

Component	Basis	Conservative	Central
Sole-source premium	10–20% competition saving, applied to €0.9–1.2bn in awards	≈ €45m	≈ €150m
Intermediation rent	1–3% of government-to-government value (US FMS analogue: 3.2%)	≈ €10m	≈ €25m
Forfeited participation (net)	15–30% workshare on €2.5bn pipeline, net of 5–10% offset cost premium	≈ €125m	≈ €250m
Programmatic lock-in	5–10% monopoly pricing delta on €2.5–4bn lifetime sustainment	≈ €125m	≈ €300m
SAFE financing terms	Positional cost; fiscal impact minimal for a surplus state	≈ nil	< €10m
Unmeasured (Falcon-type)	Unknown by construction — no impact assessments exist	n/q	n/q
Indicative total, programme life		≈ €300m	≈ €700m+

Figure 5: The bandwidth tax over the life of the current programme. Author's estimates; the basis for each row is stated and every figure is a range, not a forecast. For comparison: the three institutional prerequisites (clearances, participation policy, export controls) cost under €5 million in year one, and a bounded acquisition office roughly €15–25 million annually. The conservative column alone funds that institution for over a decade.

There is one counterfactual that should be considered amidst the procurement decisions that have been made: the *speed counterfactual*. A competitive tender run by an inexperienced state might have added two to three years to the timeline, or failed outright. Meanwhile, the cost of continued airspace blindness throughout the EU Presidency is not zero. Hence, the government-to-government route may have been the right call for the radar. However, this paper is not refuting the decision that was made, but that no published accounting demonstrates it was the right one, and the conditions that made it “the only feasible way” are being reproduced after-the-fact.

What Small States Build Instead

None of the procurement architecture this paper proposes is novel:

- **Denmark** runs defence acquisition and through-life support through DALO, a bounded agency of the Ministry of Defence.
- **Norway** split materiel acquisition out of its armed forces in 2016 to create Forsvarsmateriell, the Norwegian Defence Materiel Agency, precisely to professionalise the buying function.
- **Norway** also demonstrates what a good model for “values-based exclusion” can look like: the Council on Ethics for the sovereign wealth fund publishes its criteria, issues reasoned public decisions, and applies them consistently — which is why Norwegian exclusions are respected even by those who disagree with them.
 - Ireland's version commands little to no respect, including, presumably, from supporters of the policy watching Elbit systems delivered in Irish helicopters.
- **Finland** treats lifecycle costing as standard discipline in defence business cases.

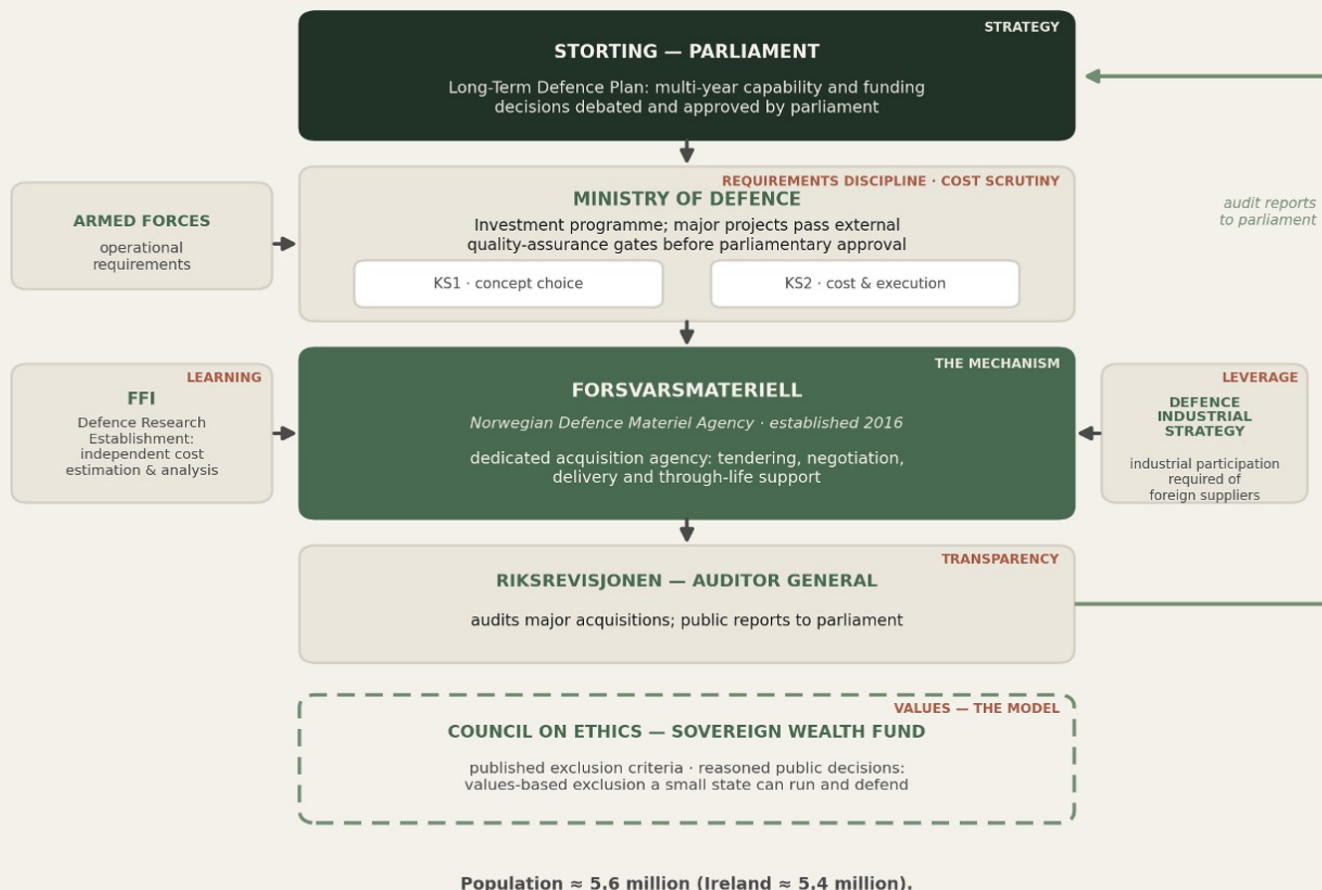
The relevant comparison is not along budget lines but along *functions*: each of the similarly sized countries procures via a named institution with a published strategy and corresponding mechanisms. Ideally, an Irish acquisition office would be bounded — built for a €1.7 billion programme and a handful of domains, not a superpower arsenal — at an estimated €15–25 million a year in steady state. And the foundation for this new institution exists. The National Strategy's Pillar 4 — capability building, professionalisation pathways, a procurement knowledge hub — is precisely the infrastructure onto which a defence acquisition profession could be build.

Hence the strategy published in August proves the State can imagine procurement institutions when it decides to. However the question the defence programme asks is why it has decided *not* to, when this is where the capital expenditure is largest.

State	Body	Function	Values machinery
Denmark	DALO (Defence Acquisition and Logistics Organisation)	Acquisition and through-life support for the Danish Defence	EU and NATO frameworks; national industrial cooperation policy
Norway	Forsvarsmateriell (Norwegian Defence Materiel Agency)	Materiel acquisition agency, separated from the armed forces in 2016	Council on Ethics model: published exclusion criteria and reasoned public decisions
Finland	Defence Forces Logistics Command	Acquisition with lifecycle costing as standard discipline	Security-of-supply doctrine
Ireland	— (departmental contracts function; Central Purchasing Body for routine goods)	Sustainment purchasing through the general public framework	2024 exclusion policy with no published architecture

Figure 6: What comparably sized states operate. The comparison is of functions, not budgets: each row above Ireland's exists as a named institution with published doctrine. Ireland's row is empty where it matters.

Figure 7 below draws one of these architectures end to end, that Ireland could feasibly replicate.



Every function in Figure 2 exists here as a named institution with published doctrine.

Figure 7: Norway's defence acquisition architecture. Political strategy anchored in parliament through the Long-Term Defence Plan; requirements and costs disciplined by external quality-assurance gates (the KS system) before approval; a dedicated materiel agency executing; independent cost analysis from the defence research establishment; industrial participation required of foreign suppliers; audit reporting back to parliament; and, in the sovereign wealth fund's Council on Ethics, the values machinery Ireland's exclusion policy lacks. Nothing in this figure is beyond a state of Ireland's size.

What Happens If Ireland Does Not Act

The armoured vehicle deal is progressing in the same way as the radar: Ireland is currently negotiating with France to buy 200–300 armoured vehicles from the French Army's Scorpion programme — at a reported €500–800 million, the biggest Army equipment purchase in the history of the State. Like the radar, it is a government-to-government deal with no competing bid; but unlike the radar, it is not yet signed. It is the last major contract where the apparatus this paper proposes could still change the terms of this procurement.

Each of the following is a direct consequence of proceeding without a procurement architecture — and each arrives on a known date.

The sustainment terms are delivered by default. Acquisition is the smaller share of a platform's lifetime cost; whereas sustainment — spares, maintenance, upgrades, training across three decades — is much larger, plausibly costing two euros for every euro of purchase price. Favourable sustainment terms can only be secured at the acquisition stage, while competitive pressure on the supplier still exists. However no institution currently

exists to identify, negotiate or hold those terms. Once the radar and armoured fleet contracts conclude without them, the State becomes a price-taker to a sole supplier for the operational life of both programmes.

The Corporate Procurement Plan codifies the status quo. The National Strategy requires every department to publish a Corporate Procurement Plan by Q2 2028. In the absence of a decision to build an acquisition function, the Department of Defence's plan will accurately describe its existing role — the purchase of fuel, uniforms and maintenance — and the State's first formal statement of defence procurement intent will document a commodity-purchasing function at the precise moment it is executing the opposite: a capability programme.

The next values-based position enters the system without policy. Without an exclusion framework, any future foreign policy stance will repeat the pattern of 2024: an exclusion that is announced in ministerial remarks but never formalized in policy, applied contract by contract at official level, without impact assessment, and at a cost the State has no apparatus to measure.

Sole-source procurement consolidates into precedent. Each un-competed award lowers the justification threshold for the next; the radar programme will be cited as the authoritative procurement procedure for future direct awards. But without a published route policy defining when government-to-government, negotiated and competitive procedures apply, improvisation ceases to be the exception in Irish defence procurement and becomes its operating policy.

THE BOTTOM LINE: Ireland's procurement gap is not only an institutional problem, but it is also a fiscal one. The State is paying a bandwidth tax — embedded in every contract, yet absent from every budget justification. The strategy published in August 2026 proves the State desires to build a procurement apparatus. However the defence programme proves it has not chosen to build it where the money is largest and the stakes are highest. Creating a €30 million defence procurement institution is not a cost; it is the cheapest money in the defence budget.

Recommendations

#	Action	What it locks in	For whom	By when
1	Publish a Defence Acquisition Strategy as a formal companion to the National Public Procurement Strategy, reporting through the Public Procurement Advisory Council: a route policy defining when government-to-government, when competitive, when joint or EU procurement, with justification standards for each	Procurement decisions made by the State rather than defaulted into	Dept of Defence / DPER (OGP)	Before the Q2 2028 mid-term review
2	Establish a bounded Defence Acquisition Office on the Danish and Norwegian model, grafted onto the National Strategy's Pillar 4 professionalisation infrastructure (≈ €15–25m steady state)	The learning from the current programme accrues in Dublin, not Paris	Dept of Defence / DPER	Phased from Budget 2027
3	Attach industrial participation and maintenance workshare requirements to all defence arrangements above €50m, beginning with the radar sustainment phase and the remaining Scorpion tranches	Leverage exercised at the only stage it exists	Dept of Defence / Enterprise Ireland	Before acquisition orders complete (2026–27)
4	Publish a Supplier Exclusion Framework: criteria, supply-chain depth, capability impact assessment, ministerial waiver, periodic review — on the Norwegian Council on Ethics model	The State can hold its values and know their price	Dept of Defence / DFA	Q2 2027
5	Upgrade Circular 40/2002 from listing to justification: an annual Dáil statement on defence acquisitions above €10m with route justification and a value-for-money benchmark, and dedicated C&AG defence audit capacity	The premium becomes visible, and therefore contestable	Oireachtas / C&AG / Dept of Defence	Budget 2027 cycle
6	Apply for SAFE and route eligible procurement through joint European frameworks	Ireland as participant, not only chair; scale it cannot generate nationally	Dept of Defence / DFA	Before the next SAFE window closes

A NOTE ON METHOD: This paper analyses publicly available information: the National Public Procurement Strategy 2026–2030, ministerial statements, the Dáil record, and press reporting of the acquisitions discussed. Cost figures are the author's estimates, presented as ranges with stated bases rather than point forecasts; comparator institutional costs are order-of-magnitude benchmarks pending published budget data. The paper takes no position on the ICJ advisory opinion or on the merits of the underlying exclusion policy: it assesses the institutional process for decision-making, not the morality of decision that are made. No classified information is discussed.

Series Context

This paper implements the procurement dimension of the Proposed National Security Strategy Framework and operationalises the procurement-reform commitment of The LOA Transition Architecture (Phase 2). It is the companion to *Ireland's Defence Industrial Architecture* and *Building the Institutional Infrastructure*, which set out the participation and clearance prerequisites an acquisition function would administer. The Presidency Desk briefs — particularly ReArm Europe — provide EU-side operational details.